

# How the Chinese Government Fabricates Social Media Posts for Strategic Distraction, not Engaged Argument<sup>1</sup>

Gary King<sup>2</sup>

Institute for Quantitative Social Science  
Harvard University

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<sup>1</sup>Based on joint work with Jennifer Pan (Stanford) and Margaret Roberts (UCSD)

<sup>2</sup>GaryKing.org

# Papers

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- Empirical Results:

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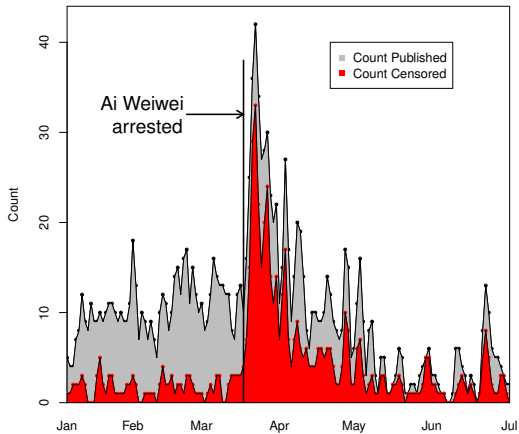
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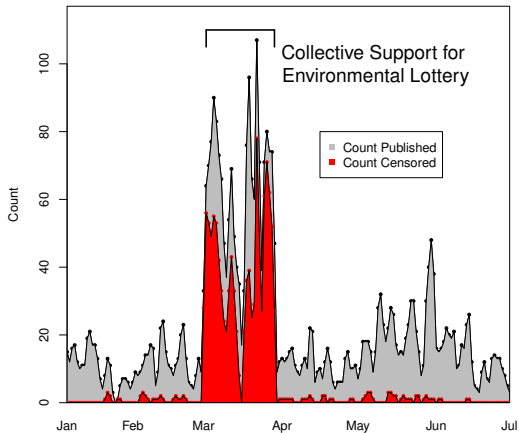
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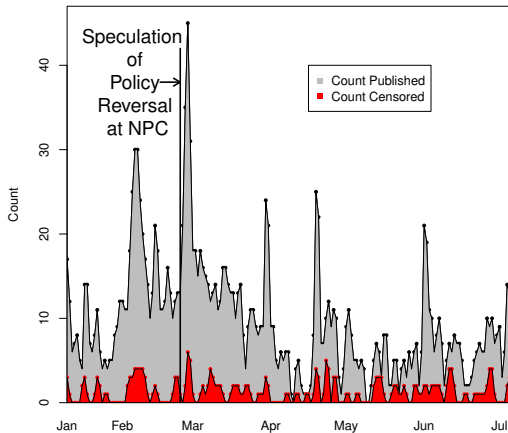




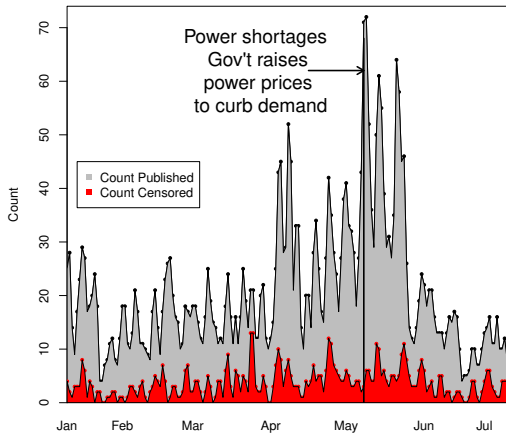
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It's antisestablishmentarianism!

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- **Distracts**; redirects public attention from criticism and central issues to **cheerleading** and positive discussions of valence issues

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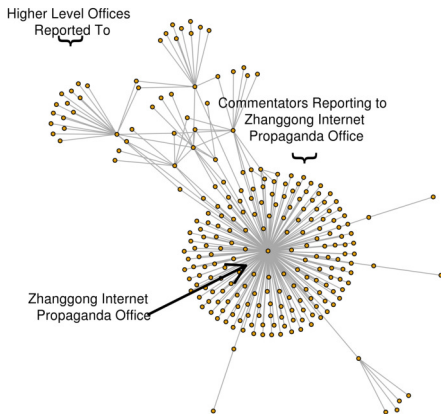
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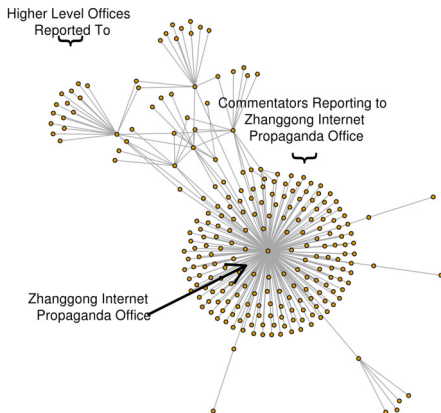
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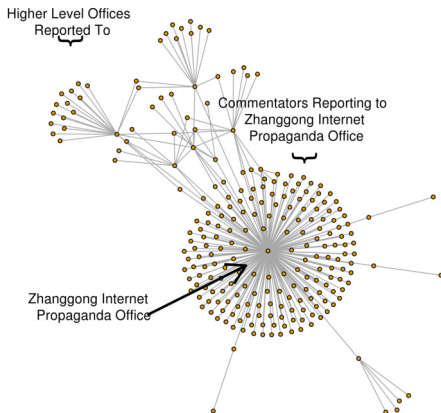


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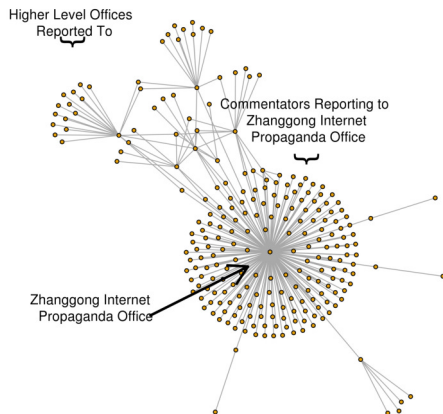
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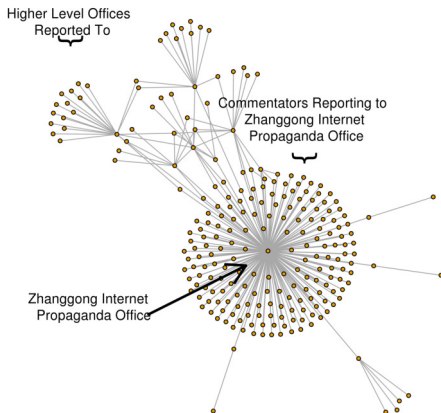
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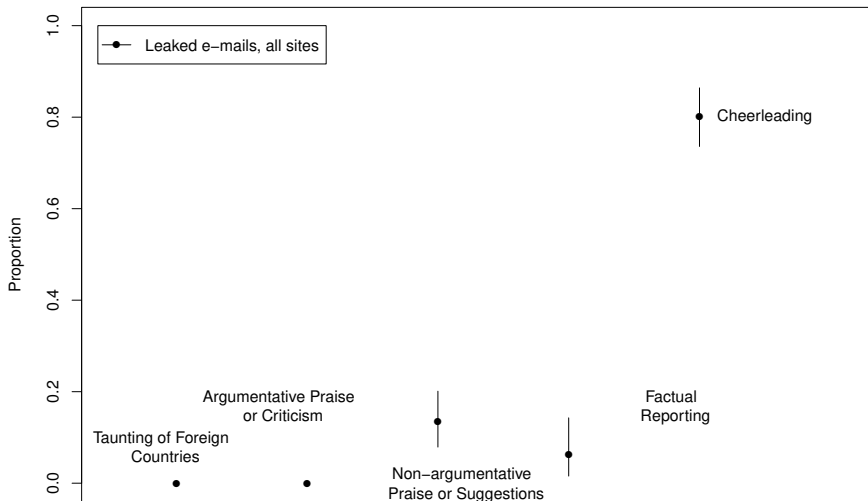
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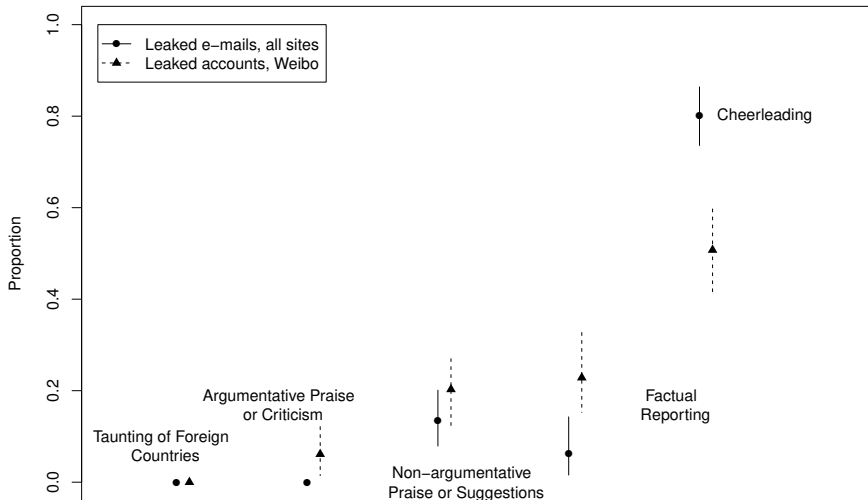
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  - 2 Leaked Zhanggong 50c weibo accounts: 167,971 posts
  - 3 Partition accounts for extrapolation (using Bayesian falling rule lists) into *ordinary* (59%) & *exclusive* (41%)
    - ↪ Accounts that engage with Zhanggong weibo
    - ↪  $\leq 10$  followers
  - 4 Unleaked posts from Zhanggong exclusive 50c weibo accounts
  - 5 Unleaked posts from exclusive 50c weibo accounts across China

# Content of Leaked and Predicted 50c Party Posts

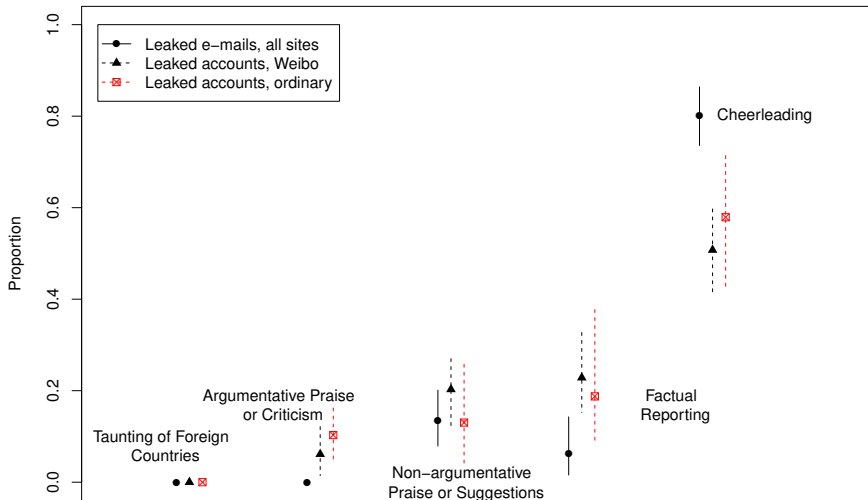
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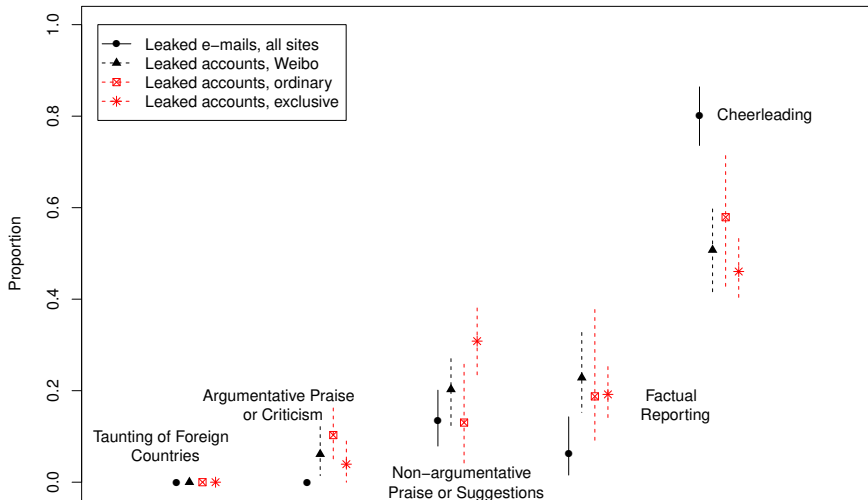
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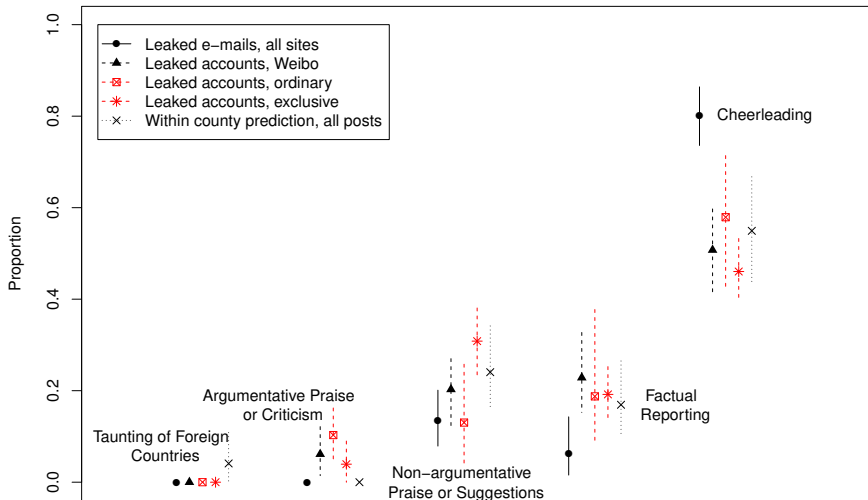


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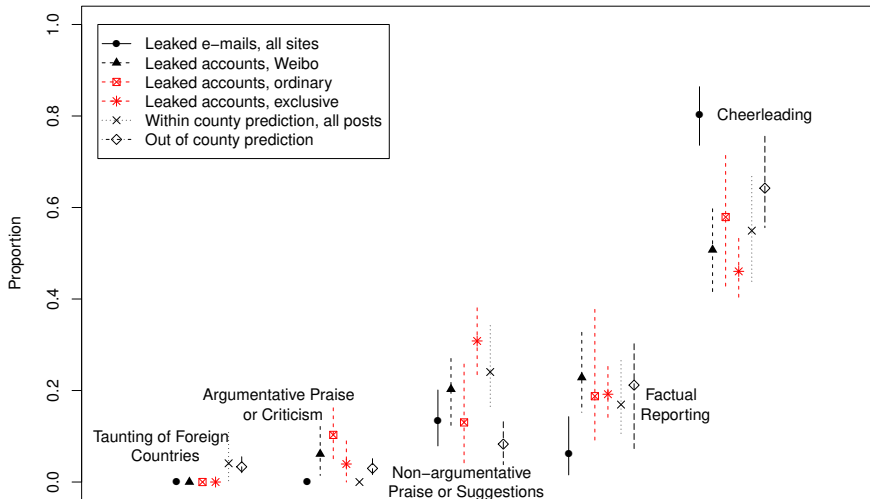




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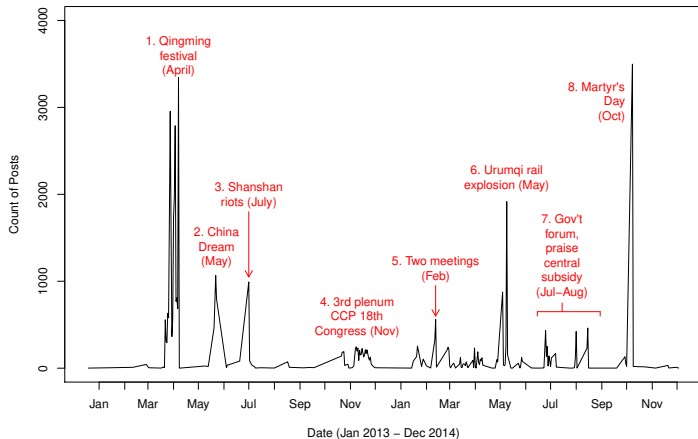
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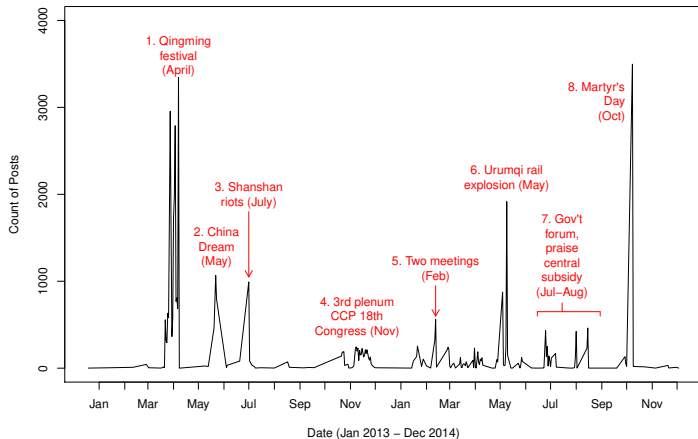
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  - 53% on government sites (a noticeable proportion of all)
  - 47% on commercial sites (1 of every 178 posts)

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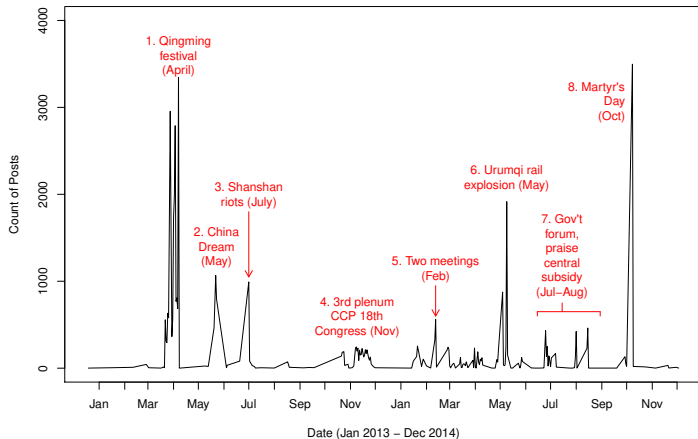
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50c Status

Origin

Percent Yes

---

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| 50c Status    | Origin       | Percent Yes |
|---------------|--------------|-------------|
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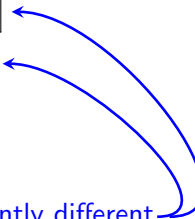
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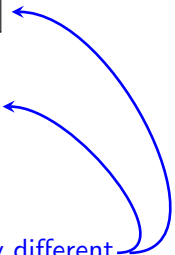
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# Theoretical Implications

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    - No censoring of criticism

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## For more information



[GaryKing.org](http://GaryKing.org)



[JenPan.com](http://JenPan.com)



[MargaretRoberts.net](http://MargaretRoberts.net)